

Learn to Be a Great Communicator: Authenticity Matters, Featuring John Horton

John Horton, Executive Coach

Authenticity matters a lot. Pat Summitt was one of the most authentic individuals to ever step on a basketball court. Pat was authentic in her interactions and her communication. As a leader, you must, of course, be honest and sincere. More important than that, you must be open and transparent; and even more important than that, you must find your own authentic voice. Bring who you are, where you come from, and what you value to your communication.

Pat Summitt: “Hey, Daddy! Can I have my old job back?” Pat’s Dad: “Yeah. I can’t pay what they pay, though.” Pat Summitt: [laughing]. That makes you real, sincere, and authentic.

So how do you do this? First, you speak with respectful candor and make sure you are acutely aware of both your audience and the situation. As Pat said, “Circumstances dictate how you need to speak or whether you need to just shut up and listen. You don’t holler at a golf tournament and you don’t whisper at a forest fire.”

Second, replace ego with empathy. Honesty plus empathy and caring create an environment for high performance to grow. Authenticity and transparency-based communication builds trust, relationships, and performance; while an overly crafted persona, supported by an inflated ego, will produce just the opposite. Authenticity leads to credibility, and Pat said the best way to maintain the credibility of compliments and criticisms is to use them meaningfully. Don’t overuse them.

And finally, stay in your lane. A prerequisite for being an authentic leader is knowing your own strengths, values, and limitations. Staying in your lane comes down to if and how you can add value to a conversation.

Coach Pat Summitt

“Always be true to myself. Never, never compromise my principles. That came from my mom and dad, and it has stuck with me. When people want to lead you down the wrong path, have the courage to say, ‘I’m not going there.’”